

Flight

A bird can fly because it has wings and a very light skeleton – many of the bones are hollow. Birds have short and compact bodies that make them neat fliers too.

By flapping its wings up and down, the bird remains in the air.

There are two methods of flying; flapping, like this red-tailed minla, and gliding.

Red-tailed minla

Travelling birds

About one-third of birds spend summer in one place then when the winter sets in they fly thousands of miles to a warmer spot. Often they go to exactly the same places year after year.



Feet

The shape of birds' feet vary depending on where they live.



Eagle foot: birds of prey have sharp talons to kill and grip animals.



Perching foot: songbirds have three toes in front and one behind for perching.



Webbed foot: waterfowl have webbed feet to help them to paddle on water.



Ostrich foot: two thick toes help this flightless bird to run very fast.

Bills

The shape and size of a bird's bill, or beak, can show what they eat.



Duck: wide and flat to tear plants and filter food underwater.



Woodpecker: long and hard to chisel into wood and pick out insects.



Chaffinch: short and cone-shaped, ideal for cracking seeds.



Heron: long, ideal to stab fish underwater.

Communication

All birds have good hearing so they can respond to songs from other members of their family. Birds are well known for their tunes, and some, like this parrot, even speak.

